



Punching to glory: Jaismine Lamboria, in blue, competes against Northern Ireland's Michaela Walsh in the women's 57kg boxing final at the 2026 Commonwealth Games. PTI

Career-changing loss

Heading into the Asian Games in Hangzhou in 2023, Jaismine had been hoping to reach the final and qualify for the Olympics. She won her opening bout and looked in fine touch, taking the opening round of her second bout against Won Un-gyong of North Korea 5-0 on every judge's card. In the second round, however, she was deducted a point. She could not recover. She kept getting hit until the referee stopped the fight.

"When I came back from that competition, everyone was shocked," she says. "*Yeh kya kar diya? Jiti hui fight haar gayi.* How can she box for India like this?" she recalls.

She eventually qualified for the Olympics, but the disappointment followed her to Paris. She lost in the

first round.

For a boxer who had grown accustomed to winning, the defeats were difficult to process.

But they forced a change. "We work so hard to perform and we only get nine minutes in the ring to show it," she says. "But if we can't control our feelings, then what is the point of training this hard?"

Jaismine began working on the part of boxing that cannot be seen in a photograph.

She has consulted psychologists for three years now. Slowly, she learned to deal with the self-doubt and pressure that had once followed her into the ring. "I learned how to handle pressure and how to convert self-doubt into self-confidence," she says.

The change isn't just limited to inside the ring. "I used to be too shy," she says. "Coaches would sometimes say, Jaismine, you don't speak at all. How will you box if you are so quiet?" she recalls. She used to become nervous when somebody approached her for an interview.

Now, she says, she speaks much more freely.

That outer confidence hasn't changed who Jaismine is. Even now she describes herself as a "very quiet, bookish person". She loves reading history and is currently working her way through the Constitution of India, trying to understand why the country follows the rules and regulations that it does.

Jaismine does not see any contradiction between that person and the boxer who steps onto the canvas. "I don't think that you have to be aggressive all the time. I think you can be a technical boxer as well. And I think you need to be the right person at the right time," she says.

Last year Jaismine showed just how far she'd come when she won gold in her weight class at the Liverpool World Championships. And if the Commonwealth Games is any example, she's only continued to grow.

Jaismine says she arrived in Glasgow with hardly any preparation. The first symptoms of a